

week, to talk to Milton Glass. Mr. Glass was the Gillette vice president in charge of giving Wall Street the latest scoop on the company's progress, projected earnings, and so forth. After they hung up with him, the analysts quickly phoned the big shareholders, hoping to tell them what was happening before the other analysts got through.

I drove up to Boston to meet Mr. Glass. He was a perfect gentleman. During our chat in his office, he expressed a fatherly affection for the analysts who follow Gillette. Since most of them called him at least once a week, and saw him in person four times a year at the quarterly meetings, he'd gotten to know them quite well.

Over a delicious lunch in the executive dining room, I told Mr. Glass my impressions: how Ms. Hall of Prudential-Bache was ebullient, Mr. Raj of Merrill Lynch was cautious, and Ms. Temple of Salomon Brothers seemed a little grumpy. He confided that Ms. Temple was in a bit of a personal slump, which might explain her negative mood about Gillette, even though her earnings estimate was high. "Last year, she picked our Body Flowers as the product of the year and it failed. I cautioned her I didn't like the product myself," he said. He was delighted with Ms. Hall's "domestic story," because it presented the same information the others had received, but in a more imaginative way.

In a few minutes with Mr. Glass, I began to understand why Wall Street analysts tend to think alike, and why their earnings estimates for Gillette fell in a very narrow range, with hardly a dime separating the optimists from the pessimists. Not only did they get their information from the same source, but Mr. Glass was determined to tell all of them the same thing at the same time, so none would be favored.

"Favoring an analyst would be a very serious matter, and I don't do it," said Mr. Glass. He reminded me of a college professor overseeing the writing of a term paper. His students—Ms. Hall, Ms. Longley, and the rest—worked with the same basic material and were expected to come up with similar conclusions, embellished with a few distinguishing flourishes.

Mr. Glass more or less confirmed that the purpose of an analyst